DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Reliving the Past: The Light of Every Festival

Derech Hashem 4:7:6, 4:8:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 7, paragraph 6, and Chapter 8, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 7 April 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Each day has its own light (paragraph 6)

Last time the class learned about Shabbat, the melakhot and the levels of holiness of the festivals. Now the Ramhal adds that beyond the general holiness of each day, each special time has something unique to it.

The Rabbi called these "huge lines". The root of them all is an order God set: any rectification that took place, or any great light that shone at a certain time, when that time comes round again, a reflection of the original light shines on us, and whoever is willing to receive it can have that rectification renewed in himself.

He quoted an analogy from one of the rabbis: the Jewish year is like a spiral staircase. Each year you come round to Rosh Hashanah at the same spot, but higher each time. A festival is not just a historical event we commemorate.

So why are the three weeks before Tisha BeAv a dangerous time? Not simply because something happened 2,000 years ago, but because the negative energy of that time returns. Why do Hazal say prayers on Purim have a better chance? Because on Purim we prayed and were answered. Why does everyone speak on Pesah of their own personal exodus from their own limitations? Because the exodus of 3,334 years ago comes back each year, nationally and personally.

"In those days, at this time"

This explains the blessing on Hanukkah and Purim: God made miracles for our ancestors "in those days, at this time." The Rabbi noted that the old texts read "and at this time", while many Sefaradim say "at this time" following the Arizal. Either way, how can we say it? Because the same light that came down then comes down again.

A participant asked whether we experience the same as our ancestors did. "Absolutely not." It is a reflection, a spark. At the Red Sea a maidservant saw more than the prophet Yehezkel; we get a spark of that.

He brought a halachah that shows this. Someone who forgets Al HaNissim may add at the end of Birkat HaMazon or the Amidah, "May the Merciful One do miracles for us." But the

Gemara forbids asking for miracles: who are you to ask God to change nature for you? The answer is that this is a time of miracles, so we may ask, because the light of then is returning.

Examples through the year

That is why on Pesah we were commanded to remember Egypt and do all the misvot of the night, reclining and eating massah: by doing them we connect with the light of that time.

In yeshivot, the Rabbi said, Shavuot is a more fearful day than Rosh Hashanah. Rosh Hashanah is for working people worried about their material circumstances. In yeshivah the great day is Shavuot: we received the Torah, and the question is whether you will get that spark again.

On Sukkot we receive again the intimacy of the Clouds of Glory, explained in the next chapter. The Ramhal asks a good question: the Clouds of Glory surrounded Israel for forty years, so why these days? Pesah is when we left Egypt, Shavuot when we received the Torah. His answer: once the Torah fixed this time for remembering the clouds, the energy comes down every year.

On Purim, which was a time of God's face being revealed, the halachah is to give to anyone who stretches out a hand without asking questions. On other days you may ask where someone is from and check his credentials; on Purim "there's no concealment, everything's open."

The Rabbi also mentioned Megillat Taanit, the ancient list of fast days and happy days marking smaller miracles, which was annulled after the destruction of the Temple. Its purpose too was to reawaken the light of those times.

"Every festival, we are remembering what happened in the past. Not just remembering, but also reliving it."

A new chapter: hames and massah (Chapter 8, paragraph 1)

With Pesah approaching, the Rabbi began the penultimate chapter, which goes through each festival. (The last chapter covers the circumstantial misvot such as mezuzah.)

Until the Exodus we were assimilated, a nation inside another nation. The Rabbi cited the verse in VaEthanan: has any god ever taken "a nation from the midst of another nation"? While there, we were enveloped in Egypt's darkness and pollution. When we left we were separated, and our bodies became fit to prepare to receive the Torah and serve God.

This resolves a question from many months ago. The Gemara says the pollution of Adam's sin ceased at Matan Torah, while the Ramhal said the Exodus. Here the Ramhal shows it is all one thing: leaving Egypt was the preparation for receiving the Torah.

A once-a-year diet

For this reason we may not have hames and must eat massah. Bread is the staple suited to our nature through the year: it has good flavour and is more digestible. "Maybe massah is nice on Seder night... by the eighth day of Pesah, massah isn't so nice anymore." We have physical bodies, and through the year that is allowed. But for a set time we refrain from leaven and live on massah, to reduce the yeser hara and the pull of materialism and draw nearer to spirituality.

We cannot do this all year. The Gemara in Yoma tells how Hazal captured the inclination for forbidden relationships, and then found that hens stopped laying eggs. We live in a physical world; God wants us to elevate it, not leave it.

So Pesah is the extreme, then seven weeks of the Omer to learn to live in the world without being pulled by it, and on Shavuot the Temple offering was the two loaves of bread, the only one of its kind. "Now enjoy the bread, but with the right frame of mind." This follows the Rambam's method for character: go to the opposite extreme for a time (the Rabbi's example was forty days), then return to the middle.

Why so strict?

The Pele Yoes writes that any sin on Pesah, even lashon hara, is more severe than during the year, because this is when we are meant to be reducing the material.

A participant asked why the restriction is only about food. The Rabbi answered that food is our biggest physical craving and is taken inside us: "You are what you eat." Spiritually, this is why even a drop of hames is forbidden on Pesah, with no nullification in sixty. His analogy: in pregnancy even a little wine or smoking can affect a child for life, because everything follows the beginning. Pesah is when we reset our physical identity for the year.

Summary

- When a time returns, a spark of the light and rectification it once brought shines again; festivals are relived, not just remembered.
- This explains "in those days, at this time", asking for miracles on Hanukkah and Purim, and the danger of the three weeks.
- Each festival brings its own light back: the Exodus, the Torah, the Clouds of Glory, the revealed face of Purim.
- Leaving Egypt separated Israel from another nation and prepared them for the Torah.
- Massah is a yearly diet from materialism; the extreme of Pesah leads through the Omer to the balanced "two loaves" of Shavuot.

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